

Photograph by **BHAWAN SINGH**

» **This symbolises India's strategic transition from a defensive posture to one with variable strategic deterrents**

» **The indigenous Agni-I paved the way for other projects such as anti-satellite weapons, hypersonic systems, missile defence shields**

» **The Agni series is a cornerstone of India's strategic defence**

"This launch has given a message to the entire world that India has the capability to design, develop and build missiles of this class and we are today a missile power"



— DR V.K. SARASWAT
Former DRDO chief



FROM THE ARCHIVES
June 15, 1989

Special Report **Agni: Chariot of Fire**

At 7.20 a.m., three minutes after Agni blasted off, Defence Minister K.C. Pant picked up the hotline set up between the Chandipur Control Centre and the PMO and said just one word to Rajiv: "Congratulations". As Pant told INDIA TODAY, "The prime minister was delighted. He asked several technical questions which showed how keenly he had followed the project."

-Amarnath K. Menon

fuel systems from the SLV-3 space launch system. It has a range of 700–1,200 km, and can carry a payload of 1,000 kg, including nuclear warheads. It was operationally deployed in 2007.

The success of Agni-I demonstrated India's capacity to build sophisticated missile systems indigenously, overcoming technological embargoes and reliance on foreign suppliers. Agni-I bolstered India's defence preparedness and established the country as a credible nuclear power. In the geopolitical context of the late 1980s, India faced significant security challenges from nuclear-armed neighbours, Pakistan and China. Agni-I, perfected for accuracy through the 1990s, provided the ability to project power beyond immediate borders, ensuring strategic depth and enhancing deterrence.

Agni-I was the beginning of India's most significant missile family. Subsequent iterations, including Agni-II, Agni-III, Agni-IV and Agni-V, extended the range, payload capacity and technological sophistication. By 2018, India had developed the Agni-V, a three-stage missile with an intercontinental range exceeding 5,000 km, capable of striking targets deep within other continents, including in Europe and the Asia-Pacific.

The development of the Agni missiles relied on innovations in areas such as propulsion systems, navigation, re-entry vehicle technology, and advanced composite materials.

The missile programme also strengthened India's bargaining power on the global stage. While the 1989 test drew criticism from Western nations, including the United States, for allegedly triggering an arms race, it underscored India's commitment to safeguarding its sovereignty amid restrictive regimes like the Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR). ■